

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BULGARIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in Bulgaria, and one winter proved it in a matter of weeks. In 2011 the government handed the US energy giant **Chevron** a permit to prospect for shale gas across a vast tract of the northeast, around **Novi Pazar** — a chance, ministers said, to break the country's dependence on Russian gas. But Bulgarians feared what the drilling would do to their water and their farmland, and a grassroots movement, "**Fracking Free Bulgaria**," rose to meet it. Through the autumn and into January the protests grew, from Sofia and Plovdiv and Varna to eleven cities at once, Bulgarians filling the squares with drums and whistles and loaves of bread held aloft to stand for the land itself. The government, which had championed the project, buckled before the sheer scale of the public refusal. On **17 January 2012 it revoked Chevron's permit**, and the next day **Parliament voted, almost unanimously across every party, for a total ban on hydraulic fracturing** — making Bulgaria the second country in Europe, after France, to outlaw the method, with a fine of a hundred million leva for anyone who broke it. In a few months, ordinary people with no power but their numbers and their voice had expelled one of the world's largest energy companies and changed the law of the land. The scale of what was overturned is worth grasping: the permit covered a field of some 4,400 square kilometres, with estimated reserves put as high as a trillion cubic metres of gas, and the government had championed it precisely to loosen the country's near-total dependence on Russian gas. That a public could reverse a project backed by both a US energy giant and the government of the day, in a matter of months, is the measure of what mass mobilisation can do in Bulgaria — and it began, in September 2011, with a handful of protests in Sofia, Plovdiv, and Varna that grew, by January, into a nationwide movement.

The fracking fight teaches two things about winning in Bulgaria — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the mobilised public, the civic movement, the environmental and EU law, the local councils and referendums, the courts, and the press — pressed together until the project was stopped and the law was changed. The second is distinctly Bulgarian. The decisive lever here is **mass civic mobilisation** — a public roused into the streets at a scale that forces the hand of a government and a parliament. Bulgaria has a living tradition of it, from the fracking ban to the great anti-corruption protests that have repeatedly shaken its politics. When enough Bulgarians say no, in public and together, the state has been made to listen. This is not a one-off but a pattern: the same capacity for mass mobilisation that banned fracking has, in other years, filled the same squares against corruption and misgovernment and forced governments from office. A Bulgarian public roused at scale is a genuine political force, and the country's leaders — who have felt its power before — know it; that memory is itself a lever a campaign can press.

But the same story carries an honest warning, and this guide states it plainly. Within months, in June 2012, Parliament **narrowed the ban**, clarifying that it struck only shale-gas fracking and not conventional drilling — a reminder that a victory can be trimmed once the crowds go home. The narrowing was, in fairness, partly a technical correction — the original blanket wording had inadvertently threatened ordinary conventional drilling as well as fracking — but it showed how quickly a hard-won text can be reopened, and later governments have periodically floated revisiting the fracking question altogether. The lesson Bulgarians drew, and which this guide will press, is that in their country a win is not finished when it is passed; it must be watched and defended long after the squares have emptied. And Bulgaria's deeper problem is not on the streets but in its institutions: it is consistently ranked among the European Union's most **corruption-troubled** states, where oligarchic influence, weak rule of law, and captured agencies mean that a lawful process cannot always be trusted to run straight. For years after it joined the European Union, Bulgaria remained under a special monitoring arrangement precisely because of concerns about corruption and the rule of law, and it continues to sit near the bottom of the EU on international measures of perceived corruption. For a community, this is not an abstraction: it means the ministry weighing your project's permit, the regulator meant to protect your water, and even a court may be within reach of the interests you are fighting — which is exactly why the public and the EU backstop matter so much more here than the paper process. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a mobilised Bulgarian public, and the captured, unreliable institutions that power must so often work around.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They grumble, sign nothing, and assume "the powerful have already decided." They never rouse the wider public, never build the civic movement, never use the environmental and EU law, never bring in the council or force a local referendum, never document the harm, never use the courts, never build the mobilisation that changes outcomes. They generate private anger without a public campaign. The gap between a

community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage or numbers. It is method.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Bulgarian system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the decision and its weak point)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build proof of harm and of every defect)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(rouse the public and build the movement)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES	(environmental law, EU law, referendums, and the courts)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(make the fight visible and win the public)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the public argument at once; the mobilised public sustains the pressure decision-makers respond to; a court filing is a headline and a headline swells a protest. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The fracking movement did exactly this — it documented the danger to water, roused the public into the streets, used the environmental and EU-law arguments, and won the national argument, all together, until the government and Parliament gave way.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Bulgaria's give communities a distinctive set:

- **Mass civic mobilisation.** A public roused into the streets at scale is Bulgaria's decisive lever — the force that banned fracking and expelled Chevron, and that has toppled governments. Protest, when it is large and sustained, moves Bulgarian outcomes.
- **The civic movement and networks.** Grassroots groups like the anti-fracking coalition, and the environmental and anti-corruption networks, bring organisation, expertise, and national reach.
- **EU and Aarhus environmental law.** As an EU member bound by the **Aarhus Convention**, Bulgaria guarantees access to environmental information, public participation, and access to justice, with **EIA** and **Natura 2000** protections that bind even a reluctant government.
- **Local referendums.** Municipalities can hold **local referendums** on projects — a direct-democratic tool communities have used to reject mining and other developments.
- **The courts.** The administrative courts and the **Supreme Administrative Court** can review and overturn unlawful permits and decisions.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers run smoothly. **Institutions are weak and often captured:** corruption is real and pervasive, agencies can be aligned with powerful interests, and a lawful-looking process may be anything but. **Wins can be narrowed** once the crowds disperse, as the fracking ban was. **Local referendums** often founder on turnout thresholds and legal challenges. And **oligarch- or state-backed projects** are far harder to stop than a foreign company's permit. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — leaning on the public and the EU-law backstop where domestic institutions fail, and pursuing the delay, the exposure, the conditions, and the record that are often what progress actually looks like.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Bulgarian development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

Environmental authorisation. Most significant projects need an **environmental impact assessment (EIA)** and permits under Bulgaria's environmental law, administered by the **Ministry of Environment and Water** and its regional

inspectories, with special protection for **Natura 2000** sites. This is a key permit and a formal objection point — and, under EU law, a genuinely binding one.

The concession or national permit. Mining, drilling, and major infrastructure often turn on a **concession or exploration permit** granted centrally, by the Council of Ministers or a ministry — the level at which Chevron's shale-gas permit was granted, and revoked.

The municipality. Local governments control much local planning and permitting, and can hold **local referendums**; a hostile council or a referendum can block or delay a project.

Parliament. For the biggest questions — a moratorium, a ban, a change in the law — the **National Assembly** is the arena, as it was for the fracking ban. Mass public pressure is what moves it. This is a crucial and hopeful point: because the gravest decisions are ultimately political, they are open to political pressure right up to the vote, and a parliament that would never have volunteered a ban can be brought to pass one overwhelmingly once the public has spoken. A community that grasps this does not treat a project blessed by the government as settled; it treats the National Assembly as a body that can be turned, as it was turned against Chevron in a single winter.

The courts. The administrative courts and the **Supreme Administrative Court** review the legality of permits, plans, and EIA decisions.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a proposal, into the **EIA and permitting** process, through any **concession** grant, with **local planning and possible referendums** alongside, into **the courts** if challenged, and — for the gravest fights — into **Parliament and the national public arena**, before construction. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The earliest doors are the cheapest and widest: an objection at the EIA stage, the public argument, documentation, and the local council. The later doors — a court challenge, a referendum, a national mobilisation — are more demanding but real, and the fracking fight went all the way to a national ban. Find out exactly where your project stands on this path; that tells you which door is open now.

Follow the Concession, the Water, and the Money

Behind the project stand a proponent — a foreign company, a domestic firm, sometimes an oligarch or a state-linked interest — its financiers and backers, and the officials who granted the permit. Trace who owns and funds the proponent, who profits, who authorised it, and — critically in Bulgaria — **what political and oligarchic interests stand behind it**, because that shapes how captured the process may be. Two questions unlock most Bulgarian fights: **What does it do to the water, land, and health the community depends on?** and **Was it lawfully and honestly authorised, or is there a defect — or a corruption — to expose?** The environmental harm and the integrity of the process are, together, the heart of most Bulgarian campaigns.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The administrative courts and the **Supreme Administrative Court** review legality; the **Ministry of Environment** supervises assessments; the **EU institutions** and the Aarhus mechanisms stand behind the national ones, beyond the reach of any domestic lobby; anti-corruption bodies and the **Ombudsman** can be engaged; and the **civic movements, the press, and the mobilised public** watch throughout — the ultimate overseers who, in 2012, overruled a government and its parliament. In a country where domestic institutions are often captured, the **EU framework and the public** are the two overseers that most reliably answer to no local interest. Each is a separate front, and a project that offends the environment, the law, and the public rarely survives pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one door: the same well-built file — the water evidence, the EIA defect, the corruption trail — can go to the objection process, the courts, the European Commission, the anti-corruption bodies, the independent press, and the mobilised public at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close. A Bulgarian campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the mobilised public and the EU backstop as the two that reach furthest past a captured process.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Bulgarian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the **public can be roused** into the streets at scale, whether there is a **clear environmental or legal defect** (and whether

the **EU-law backstop** applies), whether the **council or a local referendum** can be brought to bear, whether the project is a **foreign company's permit** (more vulnerable) or an **oligarch- or state-backed interest** (much harder), and whether **corruption can be exposed**. Where mass mobilisation meets an EU-law defect, Bulgaria's levers are formidable, as the fracking ban showed; where the project is a captured, well-connected interest, discount the figures and lean on the public, the EU framework, and exposure.

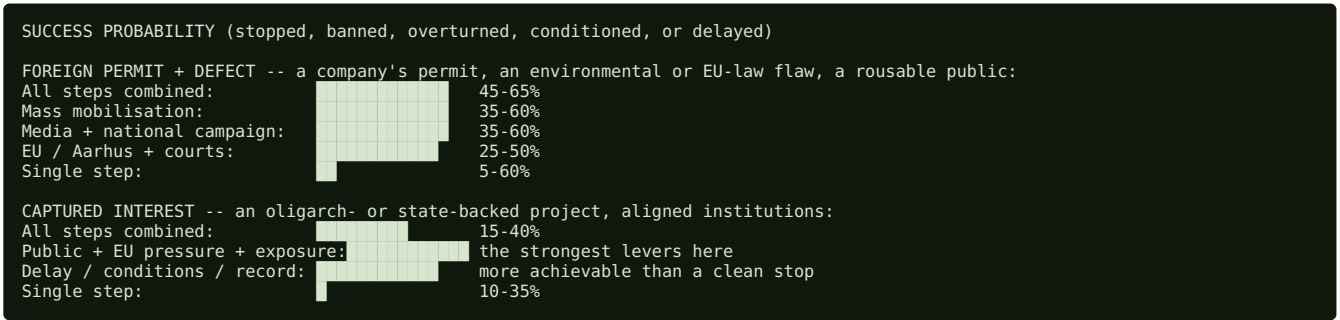
Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Objection at the EIA stage	20-45%	during review	low	On record; conditions; EU-law grounds
EU / Aarhus complaint	25-50%	months-years	low	Assessment reopened; breach found; Brussels engaged
Local referendum	20-45%	months	low-moderate	Local rejection; delay (turnout permitting)
Mass public mobilisation	35-60%	ongoing	low	Political cost decisive; ban or reversal
Court challenge (administrative)	25-50%	months-years	low-moderate	Permit or EIA overturned or conditioned
Anti-corruption exposure	20-45%	ongoing	low	Wrongdoing surfaced; interest embarrassed
Media & national campaign	35-60%	ongoing	low	The national argument won
Against an oligarch/state-backed project	10-35%	years	low-moderate	Delay, exposure, conditions, EU pressure
All steps combined (foreign permit + defect)	45-65%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Stopped, banned, overturned, or conditioned
All steps combined (captured interest)	15-40%	1-5 years	low-moderate	Delayed, exposed, conditioned; record built

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Bulgaria's real strengths are distinctive — **mass civic mobilisation**, the **civic movement**, **EU and Aarhus environmental law**, **local referendums**, and the **courts**. Its constraints are specific: **weak, often captured institutions**, wins that can be **narrowed once the crowds leave**, referendums that **fail on turnout**, and **oligarch- or state-backed projects** that are hard to stop.

A note on cost: rousing the public, objecting at the EIA stage, filing an Aarhus complaint, and pushing a local referendum are inexpensive. Court cases cost more but are within reach, especially with a civic organisation. National mobilisation takes effort more than money. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is the patient building of a civic movement and a mobilised public — exactly what carried the fracking fight from a permit to a national ban in a single winter.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Bulgaria are **mass mobilisation**, the **EU-law backstop**, and **exposure**, amplified by the courts, the civic movement, and the national press. The fracking ban shows the ceiling: a roused public expelled Chevron and changed the law in weeks. But the narrowing of that ban, and the weakness of the institutions, show the floor: a win can be trimmed, and a captured interest is far harder to stop than a foreign permit. Most Bulgarian fights sit between these poles, and the honest lesson is that civic mobilisation, the EU framework, and local democracy are real and distinctive levers — decisive against a vulnerable, unpopular project, and,

against a captured interest, best aimed at delay, exposure, EU pressure, and the record. Use the table to plan, not to predict: it tells you which combinations have historically done the most work and where to put scarce effort first. The single most important reading is that no row on its own is as strong as the rows run together — the community that rouses the public, objects at the EIA, fires the EU complaint, and exposes the corruption at once consistently outperforms the one that pins its hopes on any single move, and in Bulgaria the public and the EU rows carry the most weight precisely because they reach past the captured middle.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Mass civic mobilisation** — Bulgaria's decisive lever; the public roused into the streets at a scale that forces a government and a parliament, as it did over fracking.
2. **The EU and Aarhus law** — the backstop that binds even a captured government; the EIA, Natura 2000, and access-to-justice rights that answer to Brussels, not to a local lobby.
3. **The civic movement and exposure** — the organised networks that carry a campaign, and the exposure of corruption that a captured process most fears.
4. **The local council and referendum** — the direct-democratic and local tools that block or delay a project close to home.
5. **The courts and the record** — the legal challenge and the documentation that overturn unlawful permits and outlast a bad political moment.

What Bulgarian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **The street decides** — mass mobilisation banned fracking and has toppled governments. **The EU is the reliable backstop** — where domestic institutions fail, the EU-law rights bind. **Wins can be narrowed** — the fracking ban was trimmed within months. **Corruption is the terrain** — expect captured institutions, and make exposure part of the plan. **Referendums are real but fragile** — turnout thresholds sink many. The through-line: **rouse the public and build the movement; use the EU and Aarhus law as your backstop; force a local referendum where you can; expose the corruption behind the project; use the courts; and against a captured interest, aim at delay, exposure, EU pressure, and the record rather than expecting a clean stop — while never underestimating what a roused Bulgarian public can do.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point. Vague opposition to "the project" goes nowhere; opposition to "the exploration permit that would let a company frack for gas and poison the water of a whole region, granted without an honest environmental assessment" is a case — the case that won against Chevron. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What exactly is proposed, and what does it do to the water, land, and health?** Name the project, the proponent, and the specific harm — the aquifer, the river, the farmland, the air, the health of the community. In Bulgaria, as in the fracking fight, the **threat to water** is often the argument that rouses the public fastest.
2. **Who is behind it, and how captured is the process?** Is the proponent a **foreign company** (more vulnerable to public and legal pressure) or an **oligarch- or state-backed interest** (far harder, and more likely to have captured the process)? Naming this early tells you how much you can trust the official channels and how much you must rely on the public and the EU backstop.
3. **What permit, concession, and assessment does it need — and is there a defect?** Does it have a valid **EIA** and permits; a lawful **concession**; does it comply with the **environmental law, Natura 2000, and the EU directives** — or is one missing, defective, or unlawful? A defective EIA or a Natura 2000 breach is both a legal ground and, because it engages EU law, a lever beyond the reach of a captured national process.
4. **At what level is it decided — and can the public be roused there?** Is it an **EIA** decision, a **central concession**, a **local** matter open to a referendum, or a question grave enough for **Parliament**? And can the public be roused at that level? The fracking fight shows that even a central permit can be overturned when the national public rises.
5. **Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching?** Which officials and ministries decide; who owns, funds, and profits from the proponent, and which political interests stand behind it; which communities are affected and whether they

can be mobilised; and which civic movements, lawyers, courts, EU bodies, press, and the wider public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a company is granted a concession to mine gold using cyanide near a town, threatening the river and the groundwater, with an EIA that residents believe is a whitewash and suspicions of political backing.

Working the five questions: the harm — **cyanide near the water** — is the argument to rouse the public. The proponent's **political backing** tells you the process may be captured, so lean on the public and the EU law, not the ministry's goodwill. Does the **EIA** honestly assess the danger to water and any **Natura 2000** site — or is it defective, giving you both a court ground and an EU-law lever? Can a **local referendum** be forced, and can the town be roused? And the deciders are the ministry and the concession authority, with the courts, the EU bodies, the press, and — decisively — the public as pressure points.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the mine" to a target list: rouse the town and the wider public around the threat to water; object at the EIA stage and probe it for defects; test the Natura 2000 and EU-law angle; push for a local referendum; expose any political backing and corruption; prepare a court challenge; and make it a national story. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Bulgarians beat Chevron. It also draws on Bulgaria's long-running fights over gold mining, where communities have battled cyanide-leach projects at places like Krumovgrad, Chelopech, and Trun — the town of Trun even holding a local referendum against mining. Those fights have been harder and more mixed than the fracking victory, precisely because the interests behind them were domestic and well-connected rather than a foreign company with a revocable permit; they are a sober reminder that the vulnerability of the target shapes the odds. Notice, though, what the exercise still yields: even against a harder, well-connected target, it converts a diffuse fear into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — rouse the town around the water, object at the EIA, fire the EU complaint, push a referendum, expose the backing — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin today. That is the difference the five questions make, and it is what turns private worry into a public campaign even where the odds are long.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A judge, an EIA official, an EU complaint, a journalist, and — decisively — the public all move on evidence, not indignation. And in a system where institutions may be captured, a well-documented case is your protection against a process that would otherwise be shaped to the proponent's interest. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Official Record

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **EIA**, the **permit or concession**, and the ministry and council decisions. Use Bulgaria's access-to-information law and the **Aarhus** guarantees to obtain what is not volunteered; a refusal is itself documentable, and in a captured process, the very act of forcing disclosure matters. The gap between what the paper claims — a safe project, an adequate assessment, a lawful concession — and what the law requires and the ground shows is where cases are won. The fracking movement pressed exactly here, demanding a proper EIA and exposing how little the danger to water had been assessed. Read whatever you obtain against the grain, for what it concedes or omits — an assessment that says little about the aquifer or the cyanide risk, a concession justified in vague terms, a consultation logged as complete when objections went unanswered. In a captured system the paper is often the weakest point of the whole enterprise, because it was written to reassure rather than to withstand scrutiny; the gap between what it claims and what the law and the science require is frequently laid bare the moment an independent eye reads it closely.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth

Document the reality the paper hides. Photograph and date the **site** — the works, the drilling or mining, the discharge, the affected land and water — and geotag it. Sample and record the **water** — the river, the aquifer, the wells, the quality, the people and farms that depend on them — because in Bulgaria the water evidence is often the case; independent testing, with scientists and universities, is invaluable. Capture **before-and-after** with your own images and freely available satellite imagery. Log **incidents**: contamination, works beyond permit, damage to health or land. Record **testimony** from residents, farmers, health workers, and independent experts on the threat to water, health, and livelihoods.

Layer 3: The Defects and the Corruption

Finally, document the failures of process — and, in Bulgaria, the signs of corruption. Is there **no valid permit or concession**, or a **defective EIA** that understates the harm to water or a **Natura 2000** site, in breach of the environmental law and the **EU directives**? Was the **consultation** genuine, as Aarhus requires? And are there signs of **capture or corruption** — a permit rushed through, an assessment commissioned to reassure, a cosy tie between the proponent and the officials, a political interest behind it? Each defect is a separate ground — for an objection, a court case, an EU or Aarhus complaint, an anti-corruption exposure, and the public argument — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Bulgarian fights, because here a project that looked lawful is revealed to rest on a whitewashed assessment, to breach EU law, or to have been pushed through by an interest the public and Brussels will not ignore.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Bulgarian cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's particular defect — or its corruption.

The Permits, Concessions, and Their Paper Trail

- **The EIA and environmental permit** — read the EIA for what it understates about the water, the health risk, the cumulative impact, and any Natura 2000 site. A defective assessment is both a court ground and an EU-law lever.
- **The concession or exploration permit** — the central grant and its terms, and how and by whom it was awarded.
- **Water data** — independent testing of the river, aquifer, and wells, and the baseline that shows what is at stake; the heart of a Bulgarian water case.
- **The consultation record** — evidence of whether the public was genuinely consulted, as Aarhus requires.
- **The ownership and money** — the proponent's owners, financiers, and any political or oligarchic ties.

How to Get Them

Environmental records are held by the **Ministry of Environment and Water** and its regional inspectorates; concessions by the granting ministry or the Council of Ministers; consultation records by the municipality and the ministry. Use the access-to-information law and the **Aarhus** guarantees to obtain what is not volunteered — and, where a captured authority stonewalls, remember that the refusal itself is evidence and that the **EU framework** can be invoked over it. Work with the **civic and environmental organisations** — the networks that carried the fracking fight and the anti-mining campaigns — and with universities and independent scientists, who hold expertise, testing capacity, and records a lone community cannot assemble. Move early: an objection entered while the EIA is under review, and water baselines taken before the works begin, carry far more weight than the same point made later, and the deadlines for objections and appeals are firm. A practical discipline: from the day a project is known, keep a shared calendar of every consultation and appeal deadline and assign someone to own it, and begin independent water testing at once, because a baseline taken before the drilling or mining starts is irreplaceable — it is the only way to prove, later, what the project changed. In a captured system, where the official monitoring may not be trusted, your own independent, well-dated water data is worth more than any assurance the authorities provide.

The Ground Evidence

- **Independent water testing and monitoring** — the single most valuable evidence in a Bulgarian fight: contamination, cyanide or chemical risk, flow and supply, mapped to the people who depend on the source.
- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the site, the works, the discharge, the affected land and homes.
- **Satellite before-and-after** from freely available imagery.
- **Health and livelihood evidence** — testimony and, where possible, records of illness, harm to crops and animals, mapped to the water source.
- **Maps** overlaying the project, its discharge, and the affected water and any Natura 2000 site on the community.
- **The corruption trail** — ownership, financing, political ties, and any irregularity in how the permit was granted.
- **Testimony** — from residents, farmers, health workers, and independent scientists.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the EIA, the permit, the concession, the consultation, the works, and every incident and deadline — the spine of any court case, EU complaint, or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced

in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a resident, a lawyer, a scientist, a journalist, an EU official, and a judge — and the mobilised public — all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the proponent's lawyers challenge it. In a country where the process itself may be bent, the well-kept, well-sourced file is also your strongest protection: it is far harder to bury a project's harm when the evidence is documented, public, and ready for Brussels and the courts.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ROUSE THE PUBLIC AND BUILD THE MOVEMENT

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Organised, roused people do — and in Bulgaria that is the whole story. The fracking ban was won by a public that filled the squares of eleven cities and a grassroots movement that gave that public a plan. A Bulgarian campaign's strength is the scale of the public it rouses and the movement it builds to sustain it.

Phase 1: The Core and the Movement

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people who will carry the work — and build outward into a **movement**, because in Bulgaria mobilisation at scale is what wins. Assign roles: environment and documentation, legal and EU liaison, movement and coalition liaison, media and mobilisation, and — given the terrain — corruption research. Root the campaign locally but think nationally, because the fracking fight shows that a local threat can become a national cause. Agree on the goal — the permit revoked, the concession stopped, a moratorium or ban won, the water protected — and on what you will and will not accept. Decide early, too, how vulnerable your target is, because it sets the realistic aim: a foreign company's revocable permit, like Chevron's, can be beaten outright by a roused public, while a domestic, oligarch-backed concession is more likely to yield only to a longer campaign of exposure, EU pressure, and delay. Name the kind of fight you are in, build around it, and keep the other doors open.

Phase 2: The Public and the Coalition

Then widen deliberately, and broadly. Bring in **neighbours, farmers, and the wider public**; the **civic and environmental movements** — the anti-fracking, anti-mining, and anti-corruption networks that already know how to mobilise; **scientists and universities**, whose testing and testimony give the fight credibility; and allies across the political spectrum, because the fracking ban passed with **almost every party** voting for it once the public had spoken. That near-unanimity is instructive: it did not reflect a sudden consensus of principle among the parties but the plain political arithmetic of a public that had made its will unmistakable, so that no party dared be seen defending the project. A Bulgarian campaign's task, then, is less to convert the politicians than to make the public's opposition so large and so visible that the politicians convert themselves — which is what a broad, cross-party, whole-community movement achieves. Reach the national civic networks, and — through the EU and Aarhus channels — international environmental and anti-corruption allies who can bring Brussels to bear. The fracking movement drew its power from exactly this breadth — farmers, environmentalists, scientists, and ordinary citizens across the country as one — which is precisely the spread a winning Bulgarian campaign needs, and the only spread that can force a parliament's hand.

A worked coalition example. Facing a cyanide gold mine, the affected town and its farmers form the base; the anti-mining and environmental networks bring organising muscle and expertise; scientists document the threat to water; anti-corruption groups probe the political backing; a local referendum rallies the community; and national press and the EU channels carry the fight beyond the reach of a captured ministry. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the water, the law, the corruption, the local vote, and the national public — the model that beat Chevron.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and in Bulgaria they must also outlast the danger that a win, once the crowds go home, is quietly narrowed, as the fracking ban was. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — an objection lodged, a referendum forced, a wave of coverage, a batch of water data. Rotate the exhausting roles. Keep the movement broad and cross-party, since a Bulgarian campaign's power is its scale, and guard against the split — the promise of jobs or investment — that a proponent will use to divide a community. Above all, **stay mobilised after the victory**: watch for the quiet amendment, the reissued permit, the walked-back ban, and be ready to return to the streets, because in Bulgaria a win defended is worth two wins won.

Phase 4: Showing Strength

Numbers must be seen. Turn people out for EIA hearings, council meetings, referendum campaigns, and peaceful, well-documented protests — the mass, visible, national mobilisation that is Bulgaria's decisive weapon, as it was when Bulgarians filled eleven cities against fracking. Let the **scientists, the movement's leaders, and respected public voices** speak. Make the fight a national story, and carry it, where you can, to Brussels. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the ministry, the government, Parliament, the courts, the EU, and the country — that the public is roused, organised, and not going away, exactly as it demonstrated in the winter of 2012 when a government that had championed a project was made to kill it.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — ENVIRONMENTAL LAW, EU LAW, REFERENDUMS, AND THE COURTS

Bulgarian law gives communities real tools, and — crucially, in a system where domestic institutions may be captured — the **EU framework** stands behind them, answering to no local interest. You do not need a final ruling to win with them: an objection, a complaint, a referendum, or a court filing halts a project, forces disclosure, and creates leverage — though, as the fracking fight showed, the decisive blow can also come from the public and the parliament. Engage lawyers and the civic organisations early — but understand the tools yourself.

The Environmental Permit and the EIA

The first lever is the environmental process. Significant projects need an **EIA** and permits under Bulgarian and EU law, with special protection for **Natura 2000** sites. Object substantively while the EIA is under review, putting your strongest water and health evidence on the record; a deficient assessment, an understated threat to water, or an unaddressed Natura 2000 impact is a ground to demand refusal or conditions and to challenge the permit later. Even where the political will favours the project, the record you build here is the foundation of every other step — and, because it engages EU law, a foundation a captured national process cannot simply ignore.

EU Law and Aarhus: The Backstop

The second lever, and Bulgaria's most reliable, is the **EU and Aarhus framework**. As an EU member, Bulgaria is bound by the **EIA and Habitats Directives** and the **Aarhus Convention's** guarantees of access to information, public participation, and access to justice. Where a national authority is captured or a process is bent, these EU-backed rights can be invoked over its head: a complaint to the European Commission over a breach of the EIA or Natura 2000 rules, or an Aarhus complaint over denied participation, brings a power to bear that no Bulgarian oligarch controls. This backstop is what most distinguishes a Bulgarian community's legal position from that of a community outside the EU — use it. Its power is precisely that it operates on a different plane from the captured domestic process: a Bulgarian minister cannot quash a complaint lodged in Brussels, and a Bulgarian oligarch has no purchase on the European Commission or the European Court of Justice. A well-founded complaint over a botched EIA or a threatened Natura 2000 site can trigger correspondence, infringement proceedings, and pressure that a national interest is powerless to stop — which is why, in a captured system, the EU channel is often worth more than any number of domestic objections.

The Local Referendum

The third lever is direct-democratic: the **local referendum**. Bulgarian municipalities can put a project to a local vote, and communities have used this to reject mining and other developments. It is a powerful statement of the community's will and a real obstacle to a project — but be clear-eyed: **turnout thresholds and legal challenges sink many local referendums**, so plan the campaign to clear the threshold, and treat the referendum as one lever among several, not the whole strategy.

The Courts and Exposure

Finally, the **administrative courts** and the **Supreme Administrative Court** review the legality of permits, EIAs, and concessions and can overturn or condition them. A well-built legal case forces disclosure, creates delay, and builds the record. And in Bulgaria, pair the legal fight with **exposure**: where corruption or capture is behind a project, surfacing it — to the press, the anti-corruption bodies, and the EU — is often as powerful as any permit challenge, because it is the one thing a captured process cannot survive in daylight. Get help early: Bulgaria's environmental lawyers and civic organisations know exactly these procedures, the EU channels, the deadlines, and the strongest ground — and can tell you honestly where the domestic route can be trusted and where the EU backstop and the public are your real hope.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a judge, an EIA official, an EU complaint, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a mine would poison the river a whole region drinks from, on a permit resting on an EIA that ignored the danger and pushed through by a well-connected interest. That one fact becomes:

- **A public argument:** the project threatens the water your family drinks — the plain, powerful case that fills Bulgarian squares.
- **A legal argument:** the permit rests on a deficient EIA and threatens a protected site, in breach of the environmental law — grounds for objection and a court challenge.
- **An EU argument:** the project breaches the EIA and Habitats Directives and the Aarhus guarantees — a complaint to Brussels that a captured national process cannot quash.
- **A corruption argument:** a permit pushed through by a connected interest against the evidence — an exposure the process cannot survive in daylight.
- **A media argument:** an outside or oligarch interest poisoning a region's water for profit — a vivid, resonant story.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Bulgaria the arguments that most often decide things are the **public water** one, because it rouses the streets, and the **EU-law** one, because it binds even a captured government. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the court file and a claim made to the crowd can be proven in the water data; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive, and in a contested, corruption-prone arena, essential.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts and the EIA authorities want the illegality framed precisely against the specific rule — the environmental law, the EIA requirement, Natura 2000, the EU directives — with the documents, the water data, and the timeline that prove it.

The EU institutions respond to a clear breach of the directives or the Aarhus guarantees — the kind of failure Brussels will pursue regardless of any national interest.

Journalists and anti-corruption bodies need a specific, verified story with a hook: a named place and water source, a documented threat, a connected interest, a live decision.

The public, whose mobilisation is decisive, needs the argument simple, truthful, and emotionally clear: what is lost, who is behind it, and why standing up will stop it — the plain case that filled the squares against fracking.

The movement itself needs to see that the fight is winnable and broad, so it holds together — and stays mobilised after the win. Show it the concrete milestones — an objection lodged, an EU complaint filed, a referendum forced, a strong protest, a corruption story published — because a Bulgarian fight can run for years and must survive the temptation to relax the moment a victory is announced; a movement that can see steady progress, and understands that the win must be guarded, is one that will still be watching when the powerful try to trim it.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in a country where a roused public is the decisive force and institutions are often captured, it is often *the* lever. Coverage raises the political cost of a project, reaches past captured agencies to the public and to Brussels, protects a community by making its fight visible, and turns a local struggle into the national cause that moves a parliament. The fracking ban was, in the end, won in the public mind: months of coverage of the danger to water turned a permit the government had championed into a project no party dared defend.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place and stake, a documented harm, and a live decision. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a company would poison the water a whole region drinks, on a permit pushed through against the evidence" is. Lead with your strongest verified fact — above all the water — and offer a human voice: a resident, a farmer, a scientist. In Bulgaria the story of a poisoned water source, and of a community against a powerful or foreign interest, is uniquely powerful, and the hint of corruption behind it only sharpens it.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local media** first — the outlets that reach the affected community. Then **national outlets** — Bulgaria's press and broadcasters — which carry the story into national politics, essential because Bulgarian fights are won at the national scale; be mindful, though, that parts of the Bulgarian media are themselves captured, so cultivate the **independent** outlets and journalists. Bulgaria's media environment is, by EU standards, unusually troubled — ownership is concentrated, and some outlets are tied to the very interests a community may be fighting — so identifying the genuinely independent investigative journalists and outlets, at home and abroad, is a real and necessary task. A single trusted investigative reporter who takes up the water story and the corruption trail can do more than a dozen press releases sent blind to a captured newsroom. Then, through the **EU and international networks**, the wider audience — European press, environmental and anti-corruption organisations, and Brussels itself — which reaches past any captured national process. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. In Bulgaria the **national and EU rings are decisive**, because they are where a captured process is most exposed and a mobilised public forms. The two reinforce each other: national coverage builds the mobilised public that forces the politics, while the EU ring brings a scrutiny the domestic powers cannot deflect, and a story that travels to Brussels and the European press often bounces back into Bulgarian politics with a weight it could not have carried at home alone. Aim deliberately for both. In practice this means preparing your material in a form the European press and the EU institutions can use — a clear English-language summary, the documented breach of the directives, the water data — alongside the Bulgarian-language version for the home audience, so that the same case can be pressed simultaneously at home and in Brussels. A campaign that speaks only to the domestic arena forgoes the one ring a captured national interest genuinely fears.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions and fills squares. Plan a sequence — the water data, the EIA defect, the corruption trail, the referendum, the protest — so there is always a next hook, and build your own record online so the story exists in a form journalists and citizens can find and share. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; in a contested arena where the other side may well fund its own PR, one exaggeration handed to them can cost credibility you cannot rebuild. And keep telling the story **after** the win, to guard against the quiet reversal. Verified, specific, water-and-corruption-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that, in 2012, turned a public into a force a government could not resist.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — including, crucially in Bulgaria, the bodies beyond the reach of a captured national process. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the environmental and EU law.

8A. Objection at the EIA Stage

To: the Ministry of Environment and Water / the regional environmental inspectorate **Subject:** Objection — EIA / environmental permit, [project] at [location]

As a community/person affected by [project] at [location], we object to its environmental authorisation. Our grounds, with evidence: (1) the EIA [understates/omits] the threat to [the river/aquifer] that [#] people depend on; (2) [the project risks contamination by cyanide/chemicals]; (3) [it threatens a Natura 2000 site]; (4) [the consultation was inadequate, contrary to the Aarhus Convention]. We attach independent water data. We request that the permit be **refused**, or granted only on strict conditions, and that our objection be formally answered.

8B. Complaint to the European Commission (EU-law breach)

To: the European Commission (via the EU complaints procedure) **Subject:** Breach of EU environmental law — [project],

Bulgaria

We submit that the authorisation of [project] at [location] breaches EU law: the **EIA Directive** (a deficient or absent assessment), the **Habitats Directive** (harm to a Natura 2000 site), and/or the **Aarhus Convention** (denied information or participation). We attach the EIA, the permit, our evidence, and the timeline. We ask the Commission to examine the breach and to engage the Bulgarian authorities. [This channel is beyond the reach of any national interest.]

8C. Access-to-Information Request (Aarhus)

To: [the Ministry / the concession authority / the municipality] **Subject:** Request for environmental and permit information — [project]

Under the Aarhus Convention and Bulgarian access-to-information law, we request the following for [project] at [location]: the EIA; the permit or concession and its terms; the consultation record; and the water-monitoring data held by the authority. These concern a decision affecting the water supply and our community. Please respond within the legal period; a refusal should state its legal basis.

8D. Instructing a Lawyer / Environmental Organisation

To: an environmental lawyer / a civic organisation **Subject:** [Project] — legal options, EU complaint, and a referendum

We believe the [permit/concession] for [project], of [date], is unlawful and dangerous because [the EIA understates the threat to water / it breaches Natura 2000 / the consultation was skipped]. We attach the EIA, our water data, and our timeline, and seek advice on an **objection**, a **court challenge**, an **EU/Aarhus complaint**, and a **local referendum**. Given the signs of political backing, we also seek guidance on exposure and on where the domestic process can and cannot be trusted.

8E. Letter to an Investor / Financier / Buyer

To: [the investor / parent company / financier / buyer] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and EU-law risk

We write regarding your [investment in / financing of / purchasing from] [company] in connection with [project] at [location]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "would poison the drinking water of a whole region"], and our documented concerns include [the water threat, the deficient EIA, the community's opposition, the possible EU-law breach]. We remind you that Bulgarians have expelled a major energy company and banned an entire method through overwhelming public opposition. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and EU-law risk, and we are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Petition for a Local Referendum

To: the municipal council **Subject:** Petition for a local referendum on [project]

We, the undersigned residents of [municipality], petition for a **local referendum** on [project], which would [one-line harm to the water and community]. We ask the council to schedule the referendum and to ensure a fair, well-publicised vote. We attach our signatures and our evidence, and we will campaign to ensure the turnout the law requires.

8G. Email to a Reporter (Independent National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the river / the community]

I follow your independent coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear hook: [documents and water data] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a company would poison the water a whole region drinks, on a permit pushed through against the evidence"], with [a decision] due [date] — and [signs of political backing]. It is specific, verified, and it echoes how Bulgarians beat Chevron and banned fracking. I can share the full file and connect you with residents, a scientist, and — on the corruption trail — documents. Could we talk this week?

8H. Anti-Corruption / EU Exposure Notice

To: [an anti-corruption body / the Ombudsman / EU anti-fraud channels], copied to independent press **Subject:** Irregularities in the authorisation of [project]

We report irregularities in how [project] at [location] was authorised: [sourced facts — the rushed permit, the whitewashed EIA, the ties between the proponent and officials]. We attach the record. Given the public interest and the environmental

harm, we request examination, and we are informing independent journalists and the relevant EU bodies. [Exposure is the one thing a captured process cannot survive in daylight.]

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — in a captured system, the record of a demanded-but-refused disclosure, or an ignored objection, is itself evidence, and exactly what an EU complaint or an anti-corruption body will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the environmental and EU law; attach your documentation, water data, and maps; and route them, where you can, through the civic movement, your lawyers, the independent press, and — over the head of any captured national body — the **EU channels**. The reply, or the silence, becomes part of your record, and in Bulgaria that record feeds the levers that matter most: the mobilised public, the EU-law backstop, the local referendum, exposure, and the courts.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

1. Rouse the public around the water. In Bulgaria, a public roused into the streets is the decisive force, and the threat to water is what rouses it fastest. Make the danger known and get people out (8G, 8F). In a country where the fracking fight was, at bottom, a fight about what would happen to the water beneath people's farms and homes, this is not a slogan but the single most reliable way to turn private unease into a public movement: name the water source, name who depends on it, and name what the project would do to it.

2. Object at the EIA stage and demand the documents. A substantive objection and an information request (8A, 8C) put your grounds on the record and can force disclosure — the foundation of every later step.

3. Fire the EU backstop. Where the process looks captured, a complaint to the European Commission over an EIA, Natura 2000, or Aarhus breach (8B) brings a power to bear that no local interest controls.

4. Push for a local referendum. A petition to the council (8F) can put the project to a community vote — plan hard to clear the turnout threshold.

5. Expose the corruption. Surface any political backing or irregularity to independent press and the EU (8H); it is the one thing a captured process cannot survive in daylight.

6. Document the harm to water. Independent testing and photos (Step 2) are the basis of every argument and every complaint.

7. Bring in the movement. A single letter (8D) to the anti-mining, anti-fracking, or environmental networks adds expertise, organising muscle, and national reach.

Do only the first three and you will have roused the public, put your grounds on the record, and engaged the EU backstop — the exact foundation on which Bulgarians beat Chevron. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: rouse the public around the water, object in time, fire the EU backstop.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Bulgaria's system is tilted in specific and serious ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is steep, and it is the defining feature of a Bulgarian fight. **Institutions are weak and often captured:** Bulgaria is consistently ranked among the EU's most corruption-troubled members, and an agency, a ministry, or a court process can be aligned with a powerful interest. A **whitewashed EIA**, a **rushed concession**, a **captured regulator**, and **objections that vanish without answer** are not rare accidents but familiar features. **Wins can be narrowed** once the crowds disperse, as the fracking ban was trimmed within months. **Local referendums** are undercut by turnout thresholds and legal challenges. Parts of the **media are captured**. And **oligarch- or state-backed projects** enjoy protections a

foreign company's permit does not. Where these tilts bite, the domestic process gives far less than it should — but real levers still reach past them.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts, real and distinctive levers reach past the capture.

A mass public still overrules the powerful. The fracking ban proved that a roused Bulgarian public can force a government and a parliament, whatever the interests behind a project; no captured agency can withstand the streets.

The EU is the backstop no oligarch controls. The EIA and Habitats Directives and the Aarhus guarantees answer to Brussels, not to Sofia's power-brokers; a genuine breach is a matter for the European Commission and the European courts, beyond the reach of any national interest.

Exposure is the enemy of capture. Corruption thrives in the dark; independent journalism, the anti-corruption bodies, and the EU can drag it into the light, where it cannot survive.

Local democracy still gives a community a voice. A referendum, even one that founders on turnout, is a public statement of will that a project cannot easily ignore.

The record endures. What you document — above all the water evidence and the corruption trail — outlasts a bad moment and powers the courts, the EU complaint, and the next fight.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Bulgaria is demanding, and this guide will not pretend otherwise. Mass mobilisation, the EU-law backstop, exposure, local referendums, and the courts give a community real and distinctive power, and the fracking ban shows they can expel a giant and change the law. But the institutions are weak and often captured, wins can be narrowed, referendums can founder, and the powerful are protected. So diagnose the tilt honestly: lean on the **public and the EU backstop**, not on the goodwill of captured agencies; **expose** the corruption that a bent process cannot survive; force a referendum where you can clear the threshold; use the courts, but do not rely on them alone; and **stay mobilised after the win** to guard against the quiet reversal. Where an outright stop is out of reach against a captured interest, aim at delay, exposure, EU pressure, and the record — and remember that a Bulgarian public, once roused, has done what looked impossible before.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Bulgaria, corruption is not the exception but often the terrain, so this section is not a footnote but a core part of the strategy. When a project advances through undue influence — a permit granted against the evidence, an EIA waved through, a concession handed to a connected interest, a decision that serves an oligarch rather than the public — you stop trying to persuade a captured decision-maker and start exposing and going around them.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture, which in Bulgaria are common enough to expect. A **concession or permit granted despite a clear threat to water**; an **EIA that reads as a formality**; a **regulator aligned with the proponent**; **consultation skipped or staged**, contrary to Aarhus; **objections that vanish**; a **rushed or opaque award**; and a **proponent with visible political or oligarchic ties**. Trace the ownership and the money: who really benefits, and who in power is connected to them. One anomaly may be error; in Bulgaria, a pattern is capture, and capture should be assumed possible until the process proves itself clean.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where undue influence reaches. **Ministries, regulators, parts of the courts, and parts of the media** can be aligned with a powerful interest. But even in Bulgaria, some bodies and audiences are far harder to capture: the **EU institutions** and the European courts, beyond the reach of any national lobby; the **independent press and international journalists**; the **anti-corruption and civil-society networks**; the **Ombudsman**; and — decisively — the **mobilised public**, whom no oligarch can buy and who has overruled the powerful before. Capture thrives on staying domestic and quiet; your task is to lift the matter out of its reach — to Brussels, to the independent press, and to the

streets.

What to Do

Do not confront and tip off the captured decision-maker. Instead, **document the anomaly precisely** — the permit against the evidence, the whitewashed EIA, the connected award, the ignored objection — and take it, with evidence, to the bodies and audiences beyond its control: the **EU institutions** and the anti-fraud channels, the **independent and international press**, the **anti-corruption networks and the Ombudsman**, and — above all — the **public**, through the threat to their water. Pair the exposure with the environmental case, so the corruption and the harm surface together. And protect yourself and your evidence: keep the work collective and documented, keep copies in more than one place, involve lawyers and the civic networks, and route the gravest material through the EU and the independent press, which a captured national interest cannot silence.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Bulgaria can move fast when the public rises, as it did over fracking, and slow when a captured interest digs in.

Early (Weeks 0-8): Rouse the Public, Object, Fire the Backstop

Pin down the project, the proponent, and — first — what it does to the **water**, and how captured the process may be (Step 1). Build the **core and the movement** (Step 3). Move at once on what is cheap and decisive: **rouse the public around the water** (8G, 8F); **object at the EIA stage and demand the documents** (8A, 8C); and, where the process looks captured, **fire the EU backstop** with a complaint over any EIA, Natura 2000, or Aarhus breach (8B). Begin the **water evidence and the corruption trail** (Step 2). Reach the **civic movement** early (8D). This phase lays the foundation and, in Bulgaria, the public mobilisation begun here is often what ultimately wins.

Middle (Months 2-24): Escalate on Every Front

Grow the movement and the coalition (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **court challenge**, the **local referendum**, the **EU complaint**, the **corruption exposure** (Step 4). Reach the **investors and international allies** (8E). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to EU, cultivating the independent outlets (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the fast, time-sensitive things first — an objection lodged, water baselines taken, the EU complaint filed — because those chances do not return. And sequence the rest so each lands when it bites hardest — the public roused before the decisive decision, the referendum campaign timed to clear its turnout threshold, the corruption exposure held for the moment it will do most damage — because in Bulgaria a fight is won by those who move early, keep the public engaged, and use the EU and the exposure at the points where a captured process is most vulnerable.

Later (Months 6-48+): The National Argument, and Guarding the Win

Sustain the movement; keep the record, the coverage, and the EU pressure alive. Pursue what is achievable — a **permit revoked, a concession stopped, a moratorium or ban won, the water protected** — and, against a captured interest, the **delay, exposure, EU pressure, and conditions** that are often the realistic gains. And — distinctively in Bulgaria — **guard the win**: stay mobilised, watch for the quiet amendment or the reissued permit, and be ready to return to the streets, because here a victory undefended can be trimmed, as the fracking ban was. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped and a law changed, as in 2012. Sometimes it is a captured interest exposed, delayed, and conditioned while the pressure builds. Both are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8	Rouse the public (water) Object at EIA + request docs Fire the EU backstop Start water + corruption evidence
MONTHS 2-24	Grow the movement Arguments Courts + referendum + EU + exposure Investors + international Independent media
MONTHS 6-48+	The national argument Win a ban / revocation / conditions / delay GUARD the win against reversal

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Bulgaria gives communities a genuinely powerful — and, in places, distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits, which here are as much about corruption as about any project.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Mass civic mobilisation** is Bulgaria's decisive lever — a public roused into the streets at a scale that expelled Chevron and banned fracking, and that has toppled governments. The **EU and Aarhus framework** is the reliable backstop that binds even a captured government and answers to no local interest. **Exposure** turns corruption, the terrain of most Bulgarian fights, into a weapon against the very interests that rely on the dark. **Local referendums** give a community a direct voice. And the **courts** can overturn unlawful permits. These are the levers that let ordinary Bulgarians, in a single winter, beat one of the world's largest energy companies and change the law of the land.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. **Institutions are weak and often captured**, so a lawful-looking process cannot always be trusted. **Wins can be narrowed** once the crowds disperse, as the fracking ban was. **Referendums founder on turnout**, parts of the **media are captured**, and **oligarch- or state-backed projects** enjoy protections a foreign permit does not. No guide should pretend these away; in Bulgaria, the fight is as much against capture as against the project. That is the single most important thing to internalise about fighting here: you are rarely fighting only a company and a plan, but also a process that may have been shaped to deliver them, and so a strategy that assumes a fair, functioning officialdom will fail. The strategy that works assumes the opposite — that the paper process may be bent — and therefore reaches, from the first day, for the two forces that capture cannot touch: the mobilised public and the European backstop.

So the realistic promise is this: **rouse the public around the water; object at the EIA stage and build the environmental case; fire the EU and Aarhus backstop over the head of any captured process; expose the corruption that a bent process cannot survive; force a local referendum where you can clear the threshold; use the courts; and stay mobilised after the win to guard it — running all of it together.** Do that, and against a vulnerable, unpopular project you can stop it outright, expel its backers, and change the law, as Bulgaria did over fracking; against a captured interest, you can delay it, expose it, condition it, and bring the EU and the public to bear until it cannot proceed unexamined. Do it as the Bulgarians did against Chevron — a roused public, a broad movement, and the refusal to let the powerful decide alone.

A last word on endurance and vigilance. Bulgaria's great lesson is double: that a roused public can beat a giant and change the law in a single winter — and that the win must then be guarded, because the powerful will trim it once the squares empty. The proponent counts on your fatigue, your division, and the capture of the institutions you might turn to. Its advantage is money, connections, and a bent process. Yours is the one thing capture cannot buy — a mobilised public — together with an EU backstop no oligarch controls, and the power of exposure that corruption cannot survive in daylight. Play to that. Keep the file and the water evidence, keep the corruption trail, keep the movement broad and mobilised, keep the EU pressure and the coverage alive, and treat every objection, every water test, every referendum, every EU complaint, every exposure, and every wave of protest as a brick in a wall the powerful cannot climb — and cannot quietly dismantle once you have built it.

The tools are here, and Bulgaria itself proved them: in a single winter, a roused public expelled one of the world's largest energy companies and banned an entire method of drilling. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, endurance, and a public that refuses to let the powerful decide alone — and those you supply, as the Bulgarians who filled the squares against fracking supplied them in the winter of 2012. Begin today, begin around the water, and build from there — with a simple petition among your neighbours, an objection filed while the window is still open, and a complaint to Brussels the moment the process looks bent, the three small acts from which a Bulgarian victory grows. Communities before you have stopped, banned, and overruled what looked unstoppable — a foreign giant expelled from the country, an entire method of drilling outlawed by an almost unanimous parliament, a whole region's water defended. What was won against Chevron — by a public that filled the squares of eleven cities and would not be answered with promises — can be won again by any community that rouses its neighbours around the water, fires the backstop no oligarch controls, and refuses to let the powerful decide alone. What was won against Chevron can be won again. So can yours.